



Multi- POLAR

Challenges from
a resurgent BSP
and rebel groups
like Uma
Bharati's BJ
mean the fight is
no more bipolar

56
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including one
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to local anti-
incumbency

THE EARLY ANNOUNCEMENT
OF CHOUHAN AS ITS
CANDIDATE HELPS
THE BJP'S CAUSE

sobriquet of "Paon paon wale bhaiyya" (elder brother on foot). Now, as he does the hard yards across the state, one thing is clear: people respond to him instantly as was evident during his rath yatra in September but the party needs to back up the effort to the hilt. For the regional, linguistic and caste diversity of Madhya Pradesh makes it impossible for a chief minister to perform the role Narendra Modi essays in a more homogeneous Gujarat. The party has tried to counter local anti-incumbency by dropping 56 sitting MLAs, including a minister. Yet, the rebellion has been surprisingly low-key. Senior leaders have never troubled him much. After the initial bluster, even most rebels have returned to the party fold. Although over 70 leaders have either joined other outfits like BJ or are in the fray as independent candidates, the number of serious rebels, including MLAs and some former ministers, is less than 10 in a field of 230.

Chouhan's bigger problems are with the BSP's newly-minted social engineering and Bharati's efforts to woo away chunks of OBC votes, mostly fellow Lodhis. The sadhvi is in the fray from Tikamgarh constituency, something that is bound to have a ripple effect on her pockets of influence in the Bundelkhand region. She has also patched up with Prahlad Patel to prevent division of Lodhi votes, especially in the Mahakoshal region. The BSP's likely impact is more difficult to estimate. If its strategy of wooing upper castes doesn't work, it would continue to eat away the Congress's traditional Dalit vote and help the BJP in the process. If it works and the BSP manages upper caste votes, especially in areas of its influence in Gwalior-Chambal and Vindhya regions bordering Uttar Pradesh, the advantage over the Congress could even out.

In an election without overarching issues or a wave, a strategic campaign becomes the key. The BJP has been first off the blocks with a string of

public meetings by leaders like party chief Rajnath Singh and Sushma Swaraj, who came out publicly in defence of the beleaguered Sadhvi Pragya Singh Thakur, a suspect in the Malegaon bombing case who belongs to the state. However, the cancellation of a proposed public meeting of Singh in Bhopal over poor turnout has brought in some home truths. As former Union minister Rajiv Pratap Rudy unsuccessfully tried to work up the audience on the failure of the Centre on price rise and nuclear deal late in the evening, the message became clear. Chouhan would have to log in more campaign miles and hardsell his development agenda as the electorate doesn't seem to be responding to national issues or leaders.

In a state where the Congress has no shortage of leaders, the only one who appears to have matched the BJP in starting a whirlwind campaign is Union Commerce Minister Kamal Nath. Though his job at the Centre has kept him hopping from one capital to the other, he made known his chief ministerial ambitions quite clear to the Congress circles some time back. Ironically, he had almost given up on Madhya Pradesh for the last few years, the frequent flier miles he has acquired jetting between Delhi and Chhindwara being the only contact with the state. However, the public endorsement of Nath's candidature by such powerful satraps as former chief minister and All India Congress Committee (AICC) General Secretary Digvijay Singh at a Chhindwara 'unity summit' of the party's bigwigs in August has left the party leadership badly divided. Pradesh Congress Committee (PCC) President Suresh Pachauri, not exactly the most uninspiring of leaders and campaign committee chief Ajeya Singh, son of Union HRD Minister Arjun Singh, who were thought to be the contenders for the post should the party come to power,